

"THE RAO GOVERNMENT IS NON-FUNCTIONAL."

SHARAD SAXENA



P.V. Narasimha Rao

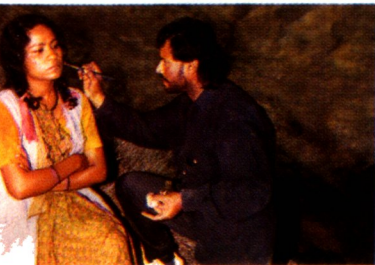
Rival Congressman N.D. Tiwari might have said so, but despite political complications like Ayodhya, Rao managed to ride through a whole five-year term, banking on his classic trait of not acting until forced to do so. But when the Jain Hawala scandal blew up, followed by Shailendra Mahato's allegations in the JMM bribery case and renewed activity in the St Kitt's forgery case of 1990, it was all over, both for him and the Congress.

Lalu Prasad Yadav

on the ordering of a probe into the Rs 950-crore fodder scam

"The people will judge whether I am involved in the loot or the one who busted the racket."

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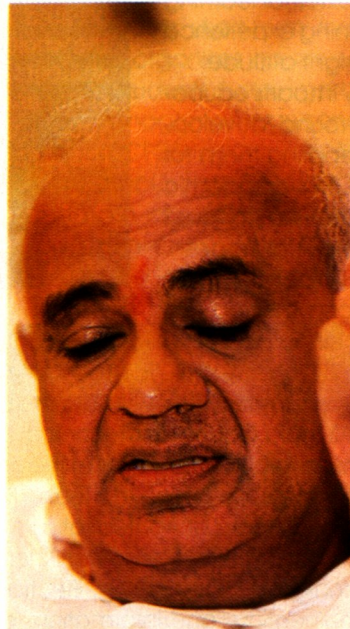
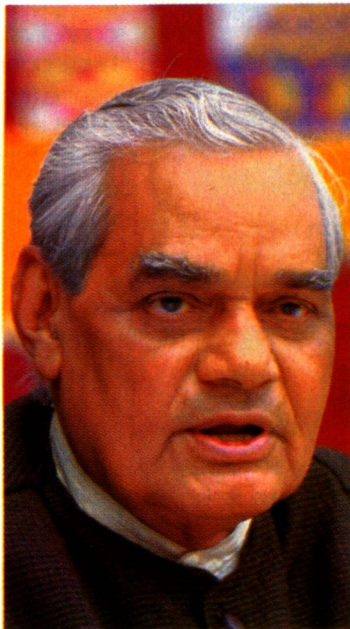
ROUGH CUT

When Shekhar Kapur reconstructed the story of a rape victim who took up arms against the caste system, *Bandit Queen* met with stiff resistance both from the censors and from the subject herself, Phoolan Devi. It was released in India two years after its release worldwide.

TWO PMs, ONE YEAR

Politics, in 1996, was a fickle game indeed. In what became a mockery of the high office, two men took oath as prime minister, each faltering in time. After the hung Parliament, first it was Atal Bihari Vajpayee trying for a majority as his government was put to vote. But the BJP's calculations went awry, and the party was unable to make it past the 200 mark. Less than two hours after Vajpayee tendered his resignation, the President summoned H.D. Deve Gowda to lead the United Front to Government. For Gowda, who led the new 13-party coalition, prime ministership was a question of just taking the path of least resistance and side-stepping key elements of the United Front's radical new agenda.

BHAWAN SINGH



- In Afghanistan, the Taliban captured the capital, Kabul, after driving out President Burhanuddin Rabbani and executing former leader Mohammad Najibullah.
- A truck laden with explosives rammed into the main gates of the Central Bank in Colombo, Sri Lanka, killing at least 86 people and injuring 1,400.
- Over 100 Lebanese

AP



civilians were killed after Israeli forces shelled the United Nations refugee compound in Qana (above).

- Thunderstorms and a tornado killed 600 in Bangladesh.

89

was India's rank amongst 101 developing countries, according to the UNDP's 1996 Human Development Report. The study said 53 per cent of Indian children under five years of age were underweight, while 64 per cent women were illiterate.